MIL-B-52488A(ME)
3 July 1974
SUPERSEDING
MIL-B-52488(MO)
31 January 1966

MILITARY SPECIFICATION

BARBED TAPE: STEEL, ZINC-COATED, FLAT, SERRATED EDGES; 50-METER REELS; AND CARRYING CASE

This specification is approved for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE

1.1 This specification covers steel barbed tape with serrated edges, 50-meter reels, and carrying cases.

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 The following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein:

SPECIFICATIONS

Federal

L-P-378	- Plastic Sheet and Strip, Thin Gauge, Polyolefin.
L-P-1183	- Plastic Molding Material, Acrylonitrile-Butadiene-Styrene (ABS), Rigid.
NN-P-71	- Pallets, Material Handling, Wood, Stringer Construction, 2-Way and 4-Way (Partial).
QQ-S-781	- Strapping, Steel, Flat and Seals.
PPP-B-636	- Boxes, Shipping, Fiberboard.
PPP-T-97	- Tape, Pressure-Sensitive Adhesive, Filament Reinforced.

FSC 5660

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Military

MIL-W-530	- Webbing, Textile, Cotton, General Purpose, Natural or in Colors.
MIL-D-52490	- Dispenser, Barbed Tape: Twisting.

STANDARDS

Federal

FED. STD. No. 595	- Colors.

Military

MIL-STD-105	- Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes.
MIL-STD-129	- Marking for Shipment and Storage.
MIL-STD-130	- Identification Marking of US Military Property.
MIL-STD-147	- Palletized and Containerized Unit Loads, 40" x 48" Pallets, Skids, Runners, or Pallet-Type Base.
MIL-STD-171	- Finishing of Metal and Wood Surfaces.

(Copies of specifications and standards required by suppliers in connection with specific procurement functions should be obtained from the procuring activity or as directed by the contracting officer.)

2.2 Other publications. The following documents form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise indicated, the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal shall apply.

AMERICAN SOCIETY FOR TESTING AND MATERIALS

E8 - Tension Testing of Metallic Materials

(Application for copies should be addressed to the American Society for Testing and Materials, 1916 Race Street, Philadelphia, PA 19103.)

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 Description. Barbed tape, reels, and carrying case shall be as shown in Figures 1 and 2 and as specified herein. The unit for issue shall consist of six reels of barbed tape (50 meters plus 30 centimeters, minus zero centimeters each) contained within a carrying case.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.2 First article (preproduction model). When specified (see 6.2), the supplier shall furnish one unit consisting of six reels of barbed tape packed in a carrying case and a specimen of tape containing a welded joint for examination and testing within the time frame specified (see 6.2), to prove prior to starting production that his production methods and choice of design detail will produce barbed tape that complies with the requirements of this specification. Examination and tests shall be as specified in Section 4 and shall be subject to surveillance and approval by the Government (see 6.3).

3.3 Material. Material shall be as specified herein and as shown on the applicable figures. Materials not specified shall be selected by the supplier and shall be subject to all provisions of this specification.

3.3.1 Steel strip. Steel strip shall be not less than 0.020 inch nominal thickness and shall have the strength to produce serrated barbed tape with a minimum breaking strength of 500 pounds. The strip shall be electroplated with zinc 0.0001 inch minimum thickness on each side. Hot dip zinc coating process may be used if the specified thickness is maintained.

3.3.2 Plastic. The plastic for the reel shall conform to L-P-1183, Type V, olive drab color No. 34087 conforming to FED. STD. No. 595.

3.3.3 Steel. Steel for the clip shall be spring steel strip.

3.4 Barbed tape. The tape shall be fabricated to the dimensions shown on Figure 1 in a manner to produce sharp barbed ends or points. The finished barbed tape shall have a minimum breaking strength of 500 pounds when tested as specified in 4.5.2.1. Fifty meters plus 30 centimeters minus 0 centimeters of tape in one continuous length, without a break, shall be spooled on each reel. There shall be not more than one welded joint in one reel of tape and not more than 1 reel of tape in 10 shall have a welded joint. The joints shall be butt welded across the full 3/4-inch width of the tape (across two opposed barbed tangs) in a manner to maintain the 500-pound minimum breaking strength of the tape and not to preclude passage through the rollers of the dispenser. Burned or damaged barbs adjacent to the weld will not be considered a defect. When tested as specified in 4.5.2.2, the tape shall not exhibit any visible cracking.

3.5 Reel. The reel shall be as shown in Figure 1, with the dimensions as shown on the figure, and shall be capable of containing 50 meters of spooled

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202640-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

tape. The plastic side disks of the reel shall be material as specified in 3.3.2. Arbor and assembly materials shall be either plastic conforming to 3.3.2 or the supplier's standard material or the entire reel including arbor may be molded from plastic material as specified in 3.3.2. The reel shall be provided with a hole in its center to fit the 3/8-inch spindle of a tape dispenser conforming to MIL-D-52490. The reel shall revolve within the dispenser in stringing or dispensing the tape.

3.5.1 Reel clip. The reel clip, to prevent the spooled tape from uncoiling, shall be as shown in Figure 1 and shall fit across the rims of the reel. The steel shall be as specified in 3.3.3 and shall be cleaned and inorganically finished either in accordance with MIL-STD-171 or the supplier's standard finish providing the finish is equal to or exceeds that specified herein.

3.6 Carrying case. The carrying case shall be a fiberboard box conforming to PPP-B-636, Style FOL, Grade W5s, as shown in Figure 2 equipped with web carrying handle securely fastened to the inner flap. The overall dimensions of the case shall be as shown in the figure. The web carrying handle shall be in accordance with MIL-W-530, Type II, Class 4, Color 007.

3.7 Identification marking. Each reel of barbed tape and each sealed carrying case shall be identified in accordance with MIL-STD-130.

3.8 Workmanship. All parts, components, and assemblies of the barbed tape and reel upon which it is spooled including castings, forgings, molded parts, stampings, bearings, seals, machined surfaces, and welded parts shall be clean and free from sand, dirt, fins, sprues, scale, flux, and other harmful extraneous material. The barbs of the tape shall be sharp, except that barb tips damaged in welding the tape will be permitted. All reel edges shall be rounded or chamfered.

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Responsibility for inspection. Unless otherwise specified in the contract or purchase order, the supplier is responsible for the performance of all inspection requirements as specified herein. Except as otherwise specified in the contract or order, the supplier may use his own or any other facilities suitable for the performance of the inspection requirements specified herein, unless disapproved by the Government. The Government reserves the right to perform any of the inspections set forth in the specification where such inspections are deemed necessary to assure supplies and services conform to prescribed requirements.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.1.1 Component and material inspection. The supplier is responsible for insuring that components and materials used are manufactured, examined, and tested in accordance with referenced specifications and standards.

4.2 Classification of inspections. Inspections shall be classified as follows:

(a) Preproduction inspection (see 4.3).
(b) Quality conformance inspection (see 4.4).
(c) Inspection of preparation for delivery (see 4.6).

4.3 Preproduction inspection.

4.3.1 Examination. The barbed tape unit shall be examined as specified in 4.5.1. Presence of one or more defects shall be cause for rejection.

4.3.2 Tests. A specimen of barbed tape containing a welded joint shall be tested as specified in 4.5.2. Failure of the tests shall be cause for rejection of the tape.

4.4 Quality conformance inspection.

4.4.1 Sampling for examination.

4.4.1.1 Barbed tape. One specimen of barbed tape from each production machine by each operator shall be selected on a daily production basis at intervals subject to the approval of the contracting officer.

4.4.1.2 Assembled units. Sampling of assembled units for examination shall be in accordance with MIL-STD-105, Inspection Level I.

4.4.2 Sampling for tests. A specimen of tape shall be prepared on a daily production basis from each welding machine by each operator at intervals subject to the approval of the contracting officer.

4.4.3 Examination.

4.4.3.1 Barbed tape. Specimens selected in accordance with 4.4.1.1 shall be examined as specified in 4.5.1.1. Presence of any defect listed shall be cause for the Government to refuse to accept subsequent production of barbed tape until corrective action has been taken to eliminate the condition which caused the rejection.

4.4.3.2 Assembled units. Samples selected in accordance with 4.4.1.2 shall be examined as specified in 4.5.1.2. AQL shall be 2.5 percent defective for major defects and 4.0 percent defective for minor defects.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202640-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the currentversion before use.

4.4.4 Test. Specimens selected in accordance with 4.4.2 shall be tested as specified in 4.5.2. Failure of a specimen to pass a test shall be cause for the Government to refuse to accept subsequent production of barbed wire until corrective action has been taken to eliminate the condition which caused the rejection.

4.5 Inspection procedure.

4.5.1 Examination.

4.5.1.1 Barbed tape. Barbed tape shall be examined as specified herein for the following defects:

Major

101. Material not as specified.
102. Dimensions not as specified.
103. Barbs formed improperly (not sharp), except that blunt barbs immediately adjacent to a weld in tape will not be counted as a defect.
104. Presence of a break in the tape.
105. Welds in tape precluding passage through rollers of dispenser.
106. Length of tape less than minimum specified.
107. More than specified permissable welded joints that affect serviceability.

4.5.1.2 Assembled units. Assembled units shall be examined as specified herein for the following defects:

108. Material of reel or case not as specified.
109. Dimensions of reel or case nor as specified.
110. Components missing, not as specified, or damaged to be inoperable.
111. Web handle case missing or damaged.
112. Fiberboard box of case not as specified.
113. Inability of the steel strip to properly dispense without breakage of the steel or damage to the barbs.

Minor

201. More than specified permissible welded joints in tape.
202. Defective spooling of tape.
203. Small crack in reel that would not preclude dispensing the tape.
204. Identification marking of reel or case missing or illegible.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4.5.2 Tests.

4.5.2.1 Tension. Test the specimen of barbed tape containing a welded joint in accordance with ASTM E8. Inability of the tape or welded joint to withstand a pull of 500 pounds shall constitute failure of this test.

4.5.2.2 Bend. Test the specimens of barbed tape containing a welded joint at room temperature by bending the specimen over a 1/4-inch mandrel to not less than 180 degrees. Straighten the specimen and then repeat the bending procedure for a total of 6 cycles. Visible cracking on the tension surface of the specimen shall constitute failure of this test.

4.6 Inspection of preparation for delivery.

4.6.1 Quality conformance inspection of pack.

4.6.1.1 Unit of product. For the purpose of inspection, the unit of product shall be a group of 60 carrying cases of barbed tape palletized for shipment.

4.6.1.2 Sampling. Sampling for examination shall be in accordance with MIL-STD-105.

4.6.1.3 Examination. Samples selected in accordance with 4.6.1.2 shall be examined for the following defects. AQL shall be 2.5 percent defective.

114.	Materials not as specified for Level A or B. Each incorrect material shall be considered one defect.
115.	Pallet loading pattern not as specified for Level A or B.
116.	Incorrect quantity of carrying cases on pallet for Level A or B.
117.	Shroud not applied for Level A.
118.	Shroud not folded at each end of load to permit water drainage.
119.	Strapping not zinc coated for Level A.
120.	Strapping not applied as specified.
121.	Marking illegible, incorrect, or incomplete.

5. PREPARATION FOR DELIVERY

5.1 Packaging. Six reels of barbed tape shall be placed in each carrying case. A piece of 1/8 to 3/16 inch thick plywood or hardboard 8-1/2 x 3 inches shall be placed between the upper and lower groups of reels to

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the currentversion before use.

provide separation. The open end of each case shall be secured with two pieces of tape conforming to PPP-T-97, Type IV, 3/4 inch wide.

5.2 Packing. Packing shall be Level A, B, or C as specified (see 6.2).

5.2.1 Level A. Carrying cases shall be unitized on pallets conforming to NN-P-71, Type II, IV, or V, Size 2. The load shall consist of six courses, each course containing 10 carrying cases placed flat and arranged as shown in Figure 3. The pattern shall be reversed for each course to form an interlocking load. The carrying cases shall be placed within each course so that the carrying handles do not face the outside of the load. A shroud, consisting of a single piece of barrier material conforming to L-P-378, Type I, Class 1, Grade A, Finish 1, 6 mils thick, and black in color shall be placed over the completed load. The shroud may be either a sheet or an envelope of appropriate size; a sheet shall be made to conform to the load by making neat folds on the short dimension of the load. A single strap 3/8 inch wide by 0.015 inch thick shall be placed girthwise around the first layer of carrying cases 2 inches above the pallet deck to secure the shroud to the load. Steel straps, 3/4 inch wide by 0.028 inch thick, shall be placed over the shroud to secure the load to the pallet. Stringer pallets shall have only five straps with the intermediate strap in the 48 inch direction omitted. All straps shall pass completely under the top deck of the pallet. Strapping shall conform to QQ-S-781, Type I or IV, Class B.

5.2.2 Level B. Carrying cases of barbed tape shall be palletized and secured as specified for Level A except that the shroud shall not be required and the strapping shall be Class A. Alternately, carrying cases may be secured to the pallet with a shrink wrap of plastic of 8 mil thickness.

5.2.3 Level C. Carrying cases of barbed tape shall be palletized in accordance with MIL-STD-147.

5.3 Marking. Marking for shipment and storage shall be in accordance with MIL-STD-129.

6. NOTES

6.1 Intended use. The barbed tape is intended for military use in the construction of combat obstacles or fences.

6.2 Ordering data. Procurement documents should specify the following:

(a) Title, number, and date of this specification.
(b) When a preproduction model is required (see 3.2).

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

(c) Time frame required for submission of preproduction model (see 3.2).

(d) Level of packing required (see 5.2). Level B packing is intended to provide economical but limited protection and should be specified only when it is known that palletized barbed tape will be held in covered storage.

6.3 Preproduction model. Any changes or deviations of production barbed tape from the approved preproduction model during production will be subject to the approval of the contracting officer. Approval of the preproduction model will not relieve the supplier of his obligation to furnish barbed tape conforming to this specification.

Custodian:

Army - ME

Review activity:

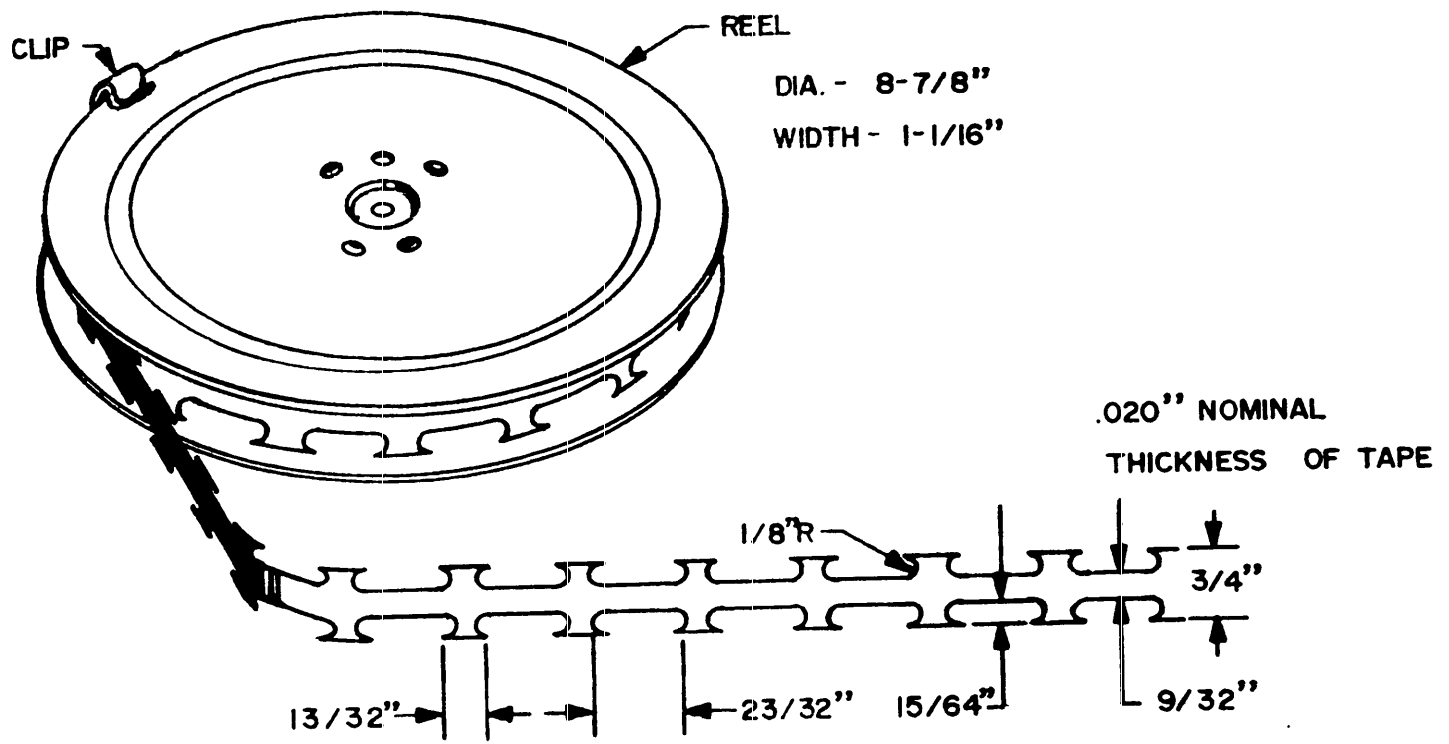
DSA - CS

Preparing activity:

Army - ME

Project No. 5660-A032

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the currentversion before use.



NOTE:

ALL LINEAR DIMENSIONS SHALL HAVE A TOLERANCE OF ± 1/32"

FIGURE 1. REEL OF BARBED TAPE

X-2481A

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026/10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

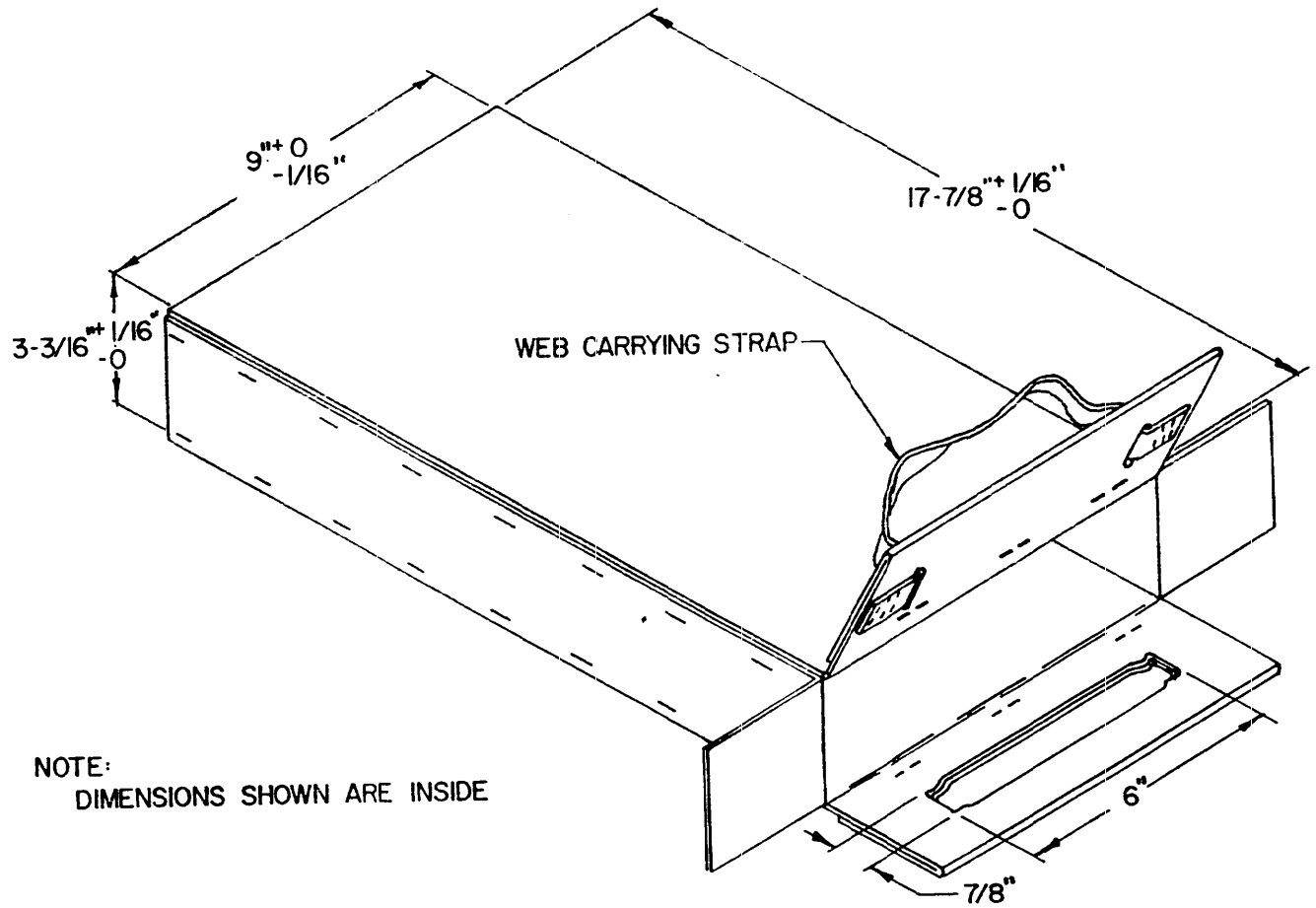


Figure 2. BARBED TAPE CARRYING CASE.

CX1952

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

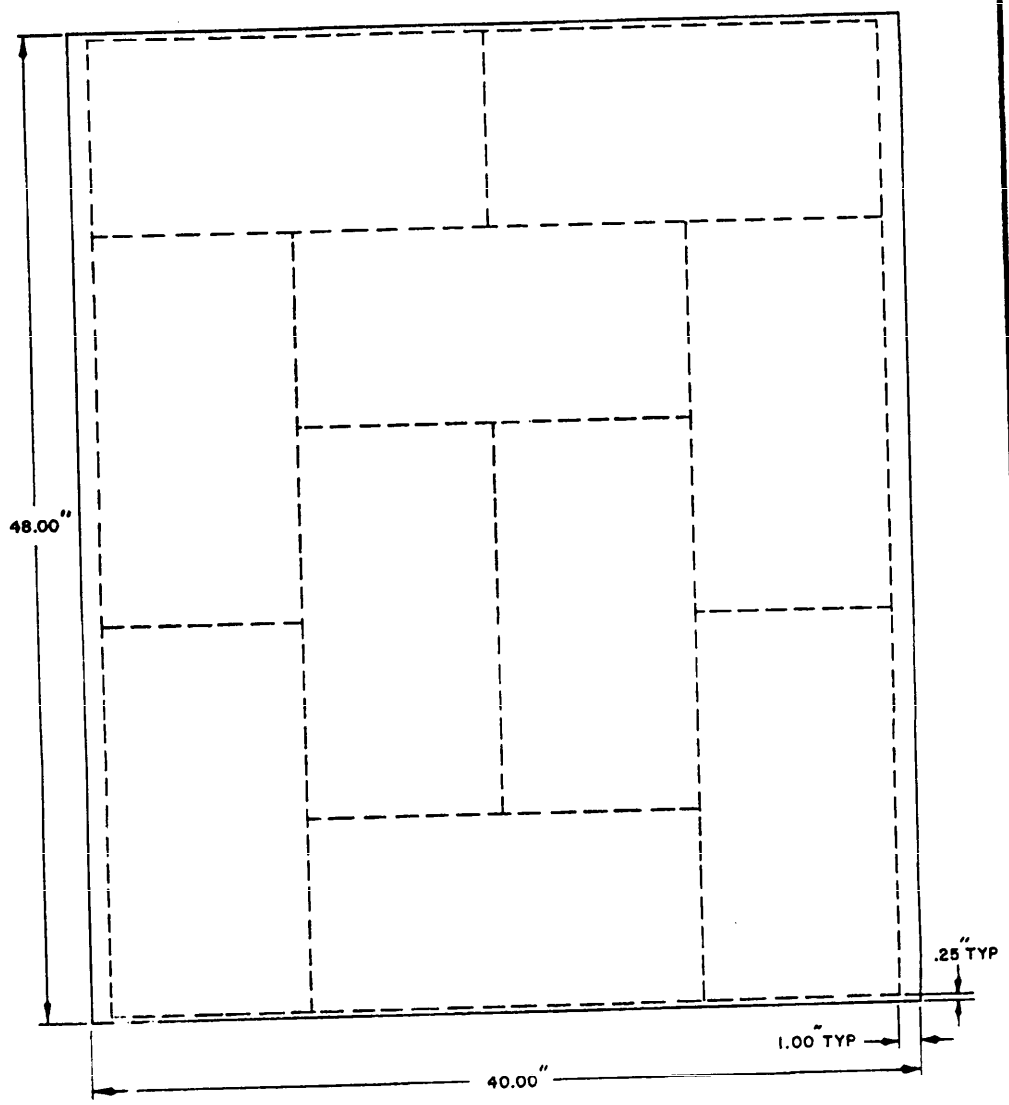


FIGURE 3. PALLET LOADING PATTERN
FOR BOXED BARBED TAPE

DX-596

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

OMB Approval
No. 22-R255

INSTRUCTIONS: The purpose of this form is to solicit beneficial comments which will help achieve procurement of suitable products at reasonable cost and minimum delay, or will otherwise enhance use of the document. DoD contractors, government activities, or manufacturers/ vendors who are prospective suppliers of the product are invited to submit comments to the government. Fold on lines on reverse side, staple in corner, and send to preparing activity. Comments submitted on this form do not constitute or imply authorization to waive any portion of the referenced document(s) or to amend contractual requirements. Attach any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document. If there are additional papers, attach to form and place both in an envelope addressed to preparing activity.

DOCUMENT IDENTIFIER AND TITLE MIL-B-52488A(ME) Barbed Tape: Steel, Zinc-Coated, Flat, Serrated Edges; 50-Meter Reels; and carrying Case

NAME OF ORGANIZATION AND ADDRESS

CONTRACT NUMBER

MATERIAL PROCURED UNDER A

☐ DIRECT GOVERNMENT CONTRACT ☐ SUBCONTRACT

1. HAS ANY PART OF THE DOCUMENT CREATED PROBLEMS OR REQUIRED INTERPRETATION IN PROCUREMENT USE?
   A. GIVE PARAGRAPH NUMBER AND WORDING.

   B. RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CORRECTING THE DEFICIENCIES

2. COMMENTS ON ANY DOCUMENT REQUIREMENT CONSIDERED TOO RIGID

3. IS THE DOCUMENT RESTRICTIVE?

   ☐ YES ☐ NO *(If "Yes", in what way?)*

4. REMARKS

SUBMITTED BY *(Printed or typed name and address - Optional)*

TELEPHONE NO.

DATE

DD FORM 1 JAN 72 1426 REPLACES EDITION OF 1 JAN 66 WHICH MAY BE USED

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 20261022T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

FOLD

POSTAGE AND FEES PAID
DEPARTMENT OF THE ARMY
DOD - 314



OFFICIAL BUSINESS
PENALTY FOR PRIVATE USE $300

Commander
US Army Mobility Equipment Research
and Development Center
ATTN: STSFB-DS
Ft. Belvoir, Va. 22060

FOLD

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-22T21:20Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.